

Olmsted County APRS Net — Check-in Board

A live web page showing which club members have been heard on APRS near the 146.820 repeater around net time.

Rochester Amateur Radio Club · Net: Sundays 9:00 PM Central · Guide version 1.0 (July 2026)

What it is

Before and during the weekly net, this tool checks the club roster against [aprs.fi](https://d-donovan.github.io/aprs-olmsted-net-check/) and lists the members whose APRS stations were **heard in the last 2 hours** and are **within 15 miles of the 146.820 repeater**. It's a quick "who's on / nearby tonight" board — a helper for check-ins, not an official log.

Where to find it

Web page: <https://d-donovan.github.io/aprs-olmsted-net-check/>

Bookmark it on your phone or computer. The page refreshes itself every 60 seconds, so you can leave it open during the net.

When it updates

- Automatically on **Sundays at 8:45, 9:00, and 9:15 PM Central** (it adjusts for daylight-saving time on its own).
- The page shows the time it was generated. Between updates it holds the last result.

How to read the page

- **Present** table — each member heard in range, with how long ago they were last heard, their distance from the repeater, and their name.
- **"N of M present"** — how many of the roster were heard in range.
- **"not present / not nearby"** — expandable list of everyone else, with the reason (heard too long ago, or too far).

How to make sure you show up

1. Be **transmitting APRS** (a position beacon) from a station within ~15 miles of the repeater.
2. Have been **heard within the last 2 hours** of the update.
3. Your callsign must be on the **RARC membership roster** (current/paid members; imported automatically — see below).
4. Transmit on one of the recognized **SSIDs**: none (home), -5 (phone apps), -7 (HT), -9 (mobile), or -10 (iGate). Example: a mobile rig usually beacons as YOURCALL-9.

“I was on but not listed” — common reasons

- Last APRS beacon was more than 2 hours ago (check your tracker is beaoning).
- You were outside the 15-mile radius when last heard.
- You transmit on an SSID that isn't in the list above.
- Your callsign isn't on the current membership sheet, or is spelled/keyed differently there.

Where the member list comes from

The roster is imported automatically from the club's own **membership Google Sheet** (the one published on the RARC website). Only **current (paid) members** are included, and it re-imports on every update, so it stays in sync as membership changes — no separate list to maintain.

Privacy & data

- Uses only **public APRS data** (the same you can see on aprs.fi) and **public callsign/name** info from the club's published membership sheet.
- No location history is stored; each update is a fresh snapshot.
- Data is courtesy of aprs.fi.

Technologies used

Technology	Role in this project
APRS (Automatic Packet Reporting System)	The amateur-radio network where stations beacon position & status over RF. The underlying data source.
APRS-IS	The internet backbone that aggregates APRS traffic worldwide; what aprs.fi ingests.
aprs.fi API	Public web API queried for each member's last-heard time and last known position. Access via a free API key.

Python 3 (standard library only)	The two programs — <code>aprs_net_check.py</code> (builds the report) and <code>import_roster.py</code> (pulls the roster). No third-party packages.
Google Sheets (published to the web)	The RARC membership roster, read as CSV to build the current member list.
GitHub	Source repository. GitHub Actions runs the scheduled builds; GitHub Pages hosts the web page; an encrypted Actions Secret holds the API key.
HTML & CSS	The report web page (self-contained, auto-refreshing).
cron (UTC)	Schedule expressions that trigger the Sunday-evening builds.
Microsoft Edge (headless)	Renders this PDF guide from HTML (build step only).

For maintainers

- **Source & docs:** <https://github.com/D-Donovan/aprs-olmsted-net-check> (see `README.md`).
- **Settings** (repeater location, radius, time window, SSIDs, roster source) live in `config.json` — edit and commit.
- **Refresh on demand:** repo → Actions → “Net report” → Run workflow. Or run `py aprs_net_check.py` locally.
- **Schedule** is in `.github/workflows/report.yml` (GitHub requires cron there, not in config).
- **API quota:** the free aprs.fi key is rate-limited; the tool backs off and the schedule is kept light. Request a higher quota from aprs.fi for heavier use.